

or hockey was one thing, but allowing him to pursue a global sport like tennis, where the risks are so high, was not easy. I appreciate my parents for their love, unconditional support, and belief in what I was trying to achieve. I dedicate this to them.

Please share your thoughts on how the success of your parents as sportspeople influenced your

career in tennis.

Being born into a legacy is a great responsibility. I could understand, at a very young age, what that responsibility meant. It was more about playing for my family and trying to emulate what my father had achieved (Vece Paes won the 1972 Olympic bronze in hockey). It was also about representing my school, city, and the wishes of more than a billion people in my country.

The responsibility became even bigger as I had to achieve excellence in a sport that did not have the infrastructure when I was growing up in the 1980s. There were no Grand Slam champions or even Asian champions to pave the path for me. Yes, there were a lot of good players like Ramanathan Krishnan, who served as a good role model, and I was lucky to travel with his son Ramesh. I am also grateful to the Amritraj family, who supported me a lot with the BAT junior programme that helped nurture my junior career. But there was no system in place to guide me on how to win Wimbledon or an Olympic medal. My dream was to win an Olympic medal and prove to Indians that we could be world champions.

What are the champions made of?

I think champions are first made in the mind. Physical prowess is just a repetition of perfect practice. By doing 10,000 hours and three million repetitions, you can master anything. It takes about 10 years. The reason that I had a long career (of 38 years, including the junior years) was because of the repetition of gym, push-ups, skipping, yoga, meditation, recovery, and the relentless practice in various aspects of the game. When I won one Grand

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